bacterial, viral, or parasitic pathogens that can pass from animals to humans. According to the World Health Organization (WHO), about 60 percent of emerging infectious diseases originate from domesticated or wild animals, and with humans continually encroaching on wildlife habitats, the pandemic highlighted the risk of disease contagion in disrupted environments.

Joined-up approach

Zoonotic diseases have existed for millennia. Rabies, for example, which is passed from dogs to humans, caused illness and death in Babylon in the early 2nd millennium BCE and is still a danger today. Scientists regularly discover new zoonotic diseases; more than 30 new human pathogens have been detected since 1990, three-quarters of which have come from animals. In the early years of the 21st century, epidemiologists focused once again on zoonotic diseases, prompted by outbreaks of life-threatening diseases such as Ebola fever, West Nile virus, avian influenza, and Mpox (monkeypox).

Since the 1960s, American veterinary epidemiologist Calvin Schwabe had been advocating bringing together the disciplines of veterinary and human medicine. In 2003, he went further, arguing for an integrated approach to optimize the health of people, animals, plants, and their shared environment: the One Health approach. It had become clear that some animals—including rodents, domesticated animals, and bats—are more likely to host zoonotic pathogens than others. Furthermore, their prevalence in areas heavily populated by people exacerbated the likelihood of crossover. Speedy urbanization, intensive livestock production, the disruption of natural ecosystems, and the habituation of some animals to urban lifestyles—all driven by rapid human population growth—were all considered major factors in the increase in zoonotic diseases. A huge increase in the global trade in animals and animal products and accelerated